As delicate as it is delicious, this pretty, pastel-green soup is scented with citrusy cardamom notes, which make a marvelous marriage with the pounded pistachios.

# creamy pistachio soup

**SERVES** 2–3 **PREP** 40 MINS **COOK** 20 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS WITHOUT HALF-AND-HALF AND CILANTRO

4½oz (125g) (shelled weight) unsalted pistachio nuts
1 green chile, cut in half and seeded
½ cup hot water
6 green cardamom pods, crushed and seeds extracted
1 small blade of mace
½ tsp coriander seeds, dry-roasted (see p25)
2 tbsp butter
2 large garlic cloves, finely chopped
small bunch of scallions (white parts only), finely chopped
1in (2.5cm) piece of ginger, peeled and finely chopped
½ tsp garam masala
2 cups hot vegetable stock
3½fl oz (100ml) half-and-half
1 tbsp chopped cilantro
salt and freshly ground black pepper

1 Bring a pan of water to a boil, add the pistachios, and cook for about 2–3 minutes. Drain in a colander and refresh under cold running water. Pat the nuts dry with paper towels, then turn out on to a kitchen towel. Give them a vigorous rub with the towel—the skins should slip off easily. Reserve a generous tablespoon for garnishing and put the rest in a food processor. Add the chile and hot water and process to a rough paste, then set aside.

2 Grind the cardamom seeds, mace, and coriander to a powder with a pestle and mortar. Melt the butter in a saucepan over medium heat, add the garlic, scallions, and ginger, and soften for 2–3 minutes. Stir in the ground spices and garam masala and cook for a few seconds, then add the pistachio paste and stock. Simmer without a lid for 10–15 minutes, stirring occasionally.

3 Blend in batches until smooth. Stir in the cream and cilantro, then season with salt and freshly ground black pepper. Serve the soup garnished with the reserved pistachio nuts coarsely chopped.